

ideas. There were hopes that the suave diplomat would be a major asset given the impeccable cv he had, but instead his continued outbursts have outweighed any contribution he may have made to the departments under his charge. Even his boss, External Affairs Minister S.M. Krishna, has been forced to rebuke him over his undiplomatic twittering. Krishna told INDIA TODAY: "I have made it quite clear that the Government business is too serious to be conducted through any tweet or any social networking site. Foreign policy is too complex and complicated a matter to be handled like this."

In the six months that he has been a minister, Tharoor has made himself

vested from his portfolio. As minister of state, Tharoor oversees the Gulf, Latin America and Africa. The Haj quota has been in the past handled by ministers who held a similar charge. Tharoor maintains, "There has been no reallocation of duties. The external affairs minister is the overall charge of the ministry and files on all matters are often routed through his office. Final decisions on the Haj were, therefore, made by him but appropriate consultations took place when we were both in Delhi." Krishna, however, sees it differently. "We had received a lot of complaints about the manner in which Haj seat selection was made, I wanted to make the sys-

tained criticism of the Nehru-Gandhi family and the MEA should not be promoting such books. Tharoor denies any impropriety, stating, "On what basis are such allegations made? The book was published in 1997 and some copies may have been purchased at that time... long before I had anything to do with the Government." But internal documents from the foreign office accessed by INDIA TODAY show that 150 copies each of the three books of the minister, including *India: From Midnight to the Millennium* were bought by the foreign office after he became a minister of state, at a cost of Rs 3,27,924 for distribution to all 150 Indian missions abroad. According to

Trouble all the Way

TWEETS

On the Government's austerity drive, he tweeted, "I'll travel 'absolutely in cattle class out of solidarity with all our holy cows'. His other tweets on the issue of his stay in a five-star hotel and visa norms also attracted criticism.

HAJ ISSUE

He handles the Haj portfolio along with Gulf, Latin America and Africa, but Krishna took away the allocation of Haj seats after many complaints. Tharoor, however, says all changes were made in consultation with him.

OVERSTEPPING

There have been allegations that he speaks on subjects that do not come under his jurisdiction, including on relations with Pakistan. Tharoor, however, says he does so only after thorough briefings by responsible officers.

more enemies than friends. Indeed, already the knives are being sharpened for another round of Tharoor-bashing, involving a slew of fresh charges against him. Among them is that the MEA's funds were used to buy books written by him, including one which has some criticism of the Gandhi family. There are also a string of complaints regarding Haj quota allocation, complaints that led to Tharoor having this responsibility di-

tem more transparent and so I thought we will put the entire weight of the ministry behind the Haj selection process," he says. Krishna now oversees the Haj quota issues.

Tharoor's growing list of controversies included an alleged misuse of his ministerial clout to plug his book *India: From Midnight to the Millennium*, which he is promoting through all Indian missions abroad. His detractors point out that it con-

official documents, on July 14, 2009 a committee of the MEA officers chaired by its then special secretary, Parvathi Sen Vyas, cleared the purchase of the three books written by the minister through File No. PMS/308/2/30/2009 along with 106 other titles written by different authors. While Tharoor may be technically right that he was not involved in the selection process, propriety demanded that he should have advised the ministry not to purchase

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